

SPOILER-FREE PREVIEW

A family story under pressure.

Read an opening scene and one genuine exhibit from the expanded narrative edition. This preview contains no solution or hidden identity disclosure.

Inside the complete game: a sustained character story, an archive of inspectable records, working pages, progressive hints, an evidence-cited solution, and an expanded aftermath.

Play alone or investigate together. Every required clue is in the supplied papers. Print in grayscale or use the PDF bookmarks and catalog. No host or outside research is needed.

Player file: 26 pages. Preview pages are selected excerpts; their archive and story labels match the full edition.

THE STORY CONTINUES

Before the chisel

Before the opening brief

Ada Reeve wanted her mother's name cut neatly, deeply enough to last. After the funeral there had been so many questions with small answers: which papers to keep together, which address to give, what wording to send the mason. She had been grateful for a task that seemed to have an end.

At Holt & Son, the order lay ready. Edith beside Roscoe. A family's ordinary completion. Then the surname in the burial index stopped the work.

"Cross," Ada said. "That isn't my father's name."

The mason did not answer immediately. He had a job waiting and a bereaved customer in front of him. Neither made the discrepancy easier to explain.

"We could leave the existing inscription as it stands and add your mother."

"And the other name?"

He turned the order a little, as though an adjustment of paper might create a simpler question. "The office may have copied it wrongly."

At the records desk, Lydia Ames would not agree that it was an error before she had traced it. Ada found that irritating. She had come to finish something for Edith, not open another set of drawers.

"My mother knew where she meant to be buried," Ada said.

"Then we should follow the instructions she left."

"This is following them."

Lydia put the index beside the order. "It may be. Let us make sure we haven't mistaken an inscription for a burial entry."

Ada heard a correction when she needed condolences. She almost gathered up the papers. Instead she asked Lydia to show her the line again.

Her father's name on the stone was one of the fixed things in her life. The sea had taken him; the memorial had given the family somewhere to stand. She had not expected a clerical surname to disturb that arrangement years later.

But somebody had occupied the line in the book. If the book was wrong, Ada wanted it corrected. If it was right, she wanted to know whom her tidy addition would pass over.

She went back to the mason and asked him to wait. He looked at the unfinished order, then crossed out no names at all.

The mason's work order

15 June 1937

Holt & Son, monumental masons / order H-88

Customer	Mrs Ada Reeve, daughter of Edith Hale
Requested work	Add Edith Hale, 1884-1937, beside the existing inscription
Site	Harbor Rest Cemetery, Briarport / G17
Existing inscription	ROSCOE HALE / 1881-1912 / THE SEA KEEPS ITS OWN
Work status	On hold pending cemetery record check

The index lists a different surname against G17. No alteration has been made. Before engraving, obtain the full burial entry and the original stone order. Confirm whether the proposed addition should refer to G17 or the adjoining space.

The inscription above is a faithful fictional transcription of the case stone. Decorative cover art is not a clue-bearing photograph.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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